

HISTORIC SESSION Then president Pranab Mukherjee addressing the joint parliamentary session to launch GST, Jun. 30, 2017

49th ANNIVERSARY

TURNING POINTS
GOVERNANCE

GOODS AND SERVICES TAX, 2017

Good, Streamlined Tax

GST marked a pivotal shift in taxation, simplifying the process, improving compliance, boosting revenues and fostering economic integration

BY ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

It was in early 2000, when at a meeting convened by then prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, the economic advisory panel—comprising the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Bimal Jalan and his predecessors I.G. Patel and C. Rangarajan—advocated for sweeping reforms in the country's tax structure. With India newly opened to global investments and seen as a burgeoning consumer market, the need for a simpler, unified tax system became evident.

The seeds of change were sown when finance min-